‘What a coincidence that the story comes up just when we’re getting ready to play them.’

He was right to be annoyed. We wanted to be ready for Madrid and we had a big game in the League the weekend before: Liverpool at home. My hamstring had felt a little sore after the Turkey game. Nothing serious: I didn’t think it would keep me out of the next United game. I was in the players’ lounge on the Saturday morning. We had an early kick-off against Liverpool. I got the call from one of the coaches, Mike Phelan, that the boss wanted to see me, so I went through to his office.

‘I don’t want to risk you, David. I want to save you for the game in the week. You’ve got this sore hamstring. I want to hold you back for Tuesday night.’

I never made it easy for the manager to give me a break. I never want a rest. I never want to miss a game. I can’t help it: I just always want to play. Not that there was any point—now or ever—in me trying to get him to change his mind.

‘I know what you’re saying but I’m not going to play you. And that’s it.’

I went out, muttering:

‘Okay. Fine. If that’s what you want.’

I was on the bench but at least I understood why, however annoyed I was about it. I’m not quite as mad for Liverpool games as Gary Neville is. He’s always got himself into trouble, over the years, riling their supporters. But, if I could, I’d always want to play against them too. Especially after the abuse we’d taken, losing the Worthington Cup Final. Especially on an afternoon when Liverpool were a goal behind and down to ten men after five minutes. Sami Hyppia got sent off after conceding a penalty and Ruud scored. It was 2–0 by the time I got on for the last half hour. We ended up winning 4–0. I was involved in the last two goals and felt great: we’d done what we needed to in the Premiership and made up points on Arsenal who only drew. I’d come off the bench and got straight into the game and the hamstring the boss had been worried about hadn’t bothered me at all. Now, Monday, we’d be off to Madrid.

Real have so many world-class players. Their stars, the *galacticos*, are as well known here as they are in Spain. We’re able to watch La Liga on television every week these days and we knew most of them from previous